

CLOSE UP

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AN AMERICAN TRAGEDY

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(*Note.*—This is the conclusion of Eisenstein's article on work in the GIK—the Moscow State Institute of Cinema. The first instalment appeared in the December *Close Up*, having arrived after the issue had gone to press, but so great was the enthusiasm it created, decision was made to include it as a sort of seasonal message of good-will!

The second part appeared in the March issue, and now this—incentive which might well promote enthusiasm to utility—to the final expulsion of drivel from our screens! Well might! It rests with you who read it. Uphill work!—*Ed.*)

The most interesting part of our work—it is the most important part of creative production—is the instruction of the students in the “treatment” of a subject and the analysis of the procedure connected therewith.

From the sublime to the ridiculous, it is only one step.

From the sublime, basic idea, expressed in a motto, to the living production, it is two hundred steps.

And if we only take one step, we get the ludicrous results of facile trash.

The student must learn to make three-dimensional, rounded productions, starting from the flat, two-dimensional patterns; from the motto to the subject without a break.

A practical problem in connexion with the analysis of a work for the purpose of serious ideological montage once confronted the writer in connexion with his own work, though under somewhat unusual social conditions.

This was at Hollywood.

Among the “Paramount” people.

And it was in connexion with the treatment and production of a work of high quality.

Even if not devoid of ideological defects and not altogether in harmony with our own sociological standpoint, Theodore Dreiser's “American Tragedy” is a first-class work. It is even a work which has every chance of being numbered among the classics of its age and country.

The fact that this material would inevitably furnish occasion for collision between two irreconcilable points of view—that of the film bosses and our own—became apparent the moment the first draft of the libretto was delivered.

"Is Clyde Griffiths guilty or not guilty in your treatment?" asked the boss of the Paramount Californian studios, B. P. Schulberg.

"Not guilty," was the reply.

"But in that case your scenario is a monstrous challenge to American society. . ."

I explained that I regarded the crime committed by Griffiths as the net result of the social conditions to whose influence he was subjected at every stage in the evolution of his character and career as unfolded in the course of the film.

"This, in my opinion, constitutes the whole interest of the work. . ."

To which they replied: "But we should prefer a strong, simple detective story about a murder. . ."

"And about a love affair between a boy and a girl. . ." they added with a sigh.

The possibility of two such radically opposite treatments of the central protagonist of the story is not really surprising.

Dreiser's novel is as broad and shoreless as the Hudson; it is as immense as life itself, and it admits of any point of view in relation to its theme, like every central fact of Nature herself. His novel is 99 per cent. exposition of facts and 1 per cent. commentary upon them. This epic of cosmic veracity and objectivity had to be worked up into a tragedy, which was unthinkable without some well-defined philosophical standpoint and direction.

The film bosses were concerned with the question of guilt or innocence from an entirely different point of view. Guilty meant unlovable. And for the principal hero to be suddenly unlovable!—What would the box-office say?

And if he were not guilty. . .

As a result of the difficulties arising out of this "confounded question," "An American Tragedy" lay untouched in the Paramount portfolio for more than five years.

It was tackled by Griffith (not Clyde this time, but the patriarch of cinematography, David Wark) and Lubitsch and a great many others.

With their customary prudence and caution this time, too, the bosses evaded a decision.

They proposed to us that we should make up the scenario "as you feel it"—and then it would be easier to judge. . .

From what has been said, it is perfectly plain that in this case, as distinct from others, the divergence of opinions did not in any way turn upon the treatment of a particular situation; it was very much more profound and far-reaching; it concerned the sociological treatment of the work as a whole.

It is curious to note how production, conceived in this way, begins to determine the structure of the individual parts; and how, above all, by its



From a film made by Harry Aslonian, a pupil of the GIK, entitled "Questions Comparison." He writes, "If it is good afterwards I can send you many photos!"

D'un film réalisé par un élève de la GIK, Harry Aslonian, et intitulé : "Questions comparées." Il nous écrit : "si le film s'avère bon par la suite, je vous enverrai de nombreuses photos."



demands, it influences the treatment and psychological interpretation of particular situations; and, in fact, the "purely formal" side of the creation of the work as a whole. Curious, too, how it suggests completely new, "purely formal" methods which, gradually, and in conjunction, help to evolve a new theoretical conception of the guiding principles of cinematography as such.

It would be difficult to set forth here the whole plot of the novel in question—to do in five lines something for which Dreiser required two stout volumes. We shall only touch upon what, viewed from outside, constitutes the climax of the tragedy—the murder itself; though the tragedy, of course, does not lie here but in the fatal course embarked on by Clyde, who is driven to commit murder by social conditions. And in our scenario the chief attention is directed to this fact.

We see how Clyde Griffiths, having seduced a young working girl employed at the work-room of which he is in charge, is unable to help her to secure an abortion, which is still strictly forbidden in the United States.

He sees himself forced to marry her. To do so, however, would absolutely shatter all his dreams of a career, since it would make it impossible for him to marry a rich heiress who is madly in love with him.

The situation itself is profoundly characteristic of America where, among the industrial middle classes, there are not as yet any caste barriers to prevent such a misalliance. In this class there still prevails the patriarchal democratic spirit of the fathers, who have not forgotten how they themselves came to the town in rags to make their fortunes. The succeeding generation is already approximating to a moneyed aristocracy; and in this connexion it is interesting to note the difference in the attitude towards Clyde adopted by his uncle and his cousin respectively.

However that may be, Clyde is faced with a dilemma: either he must renounce for ever his prospects of a career and of social success, or he must get quit of the first girl.

Clyde's adventures in his contacts with American realities have by this time already contrived to mould his psychology in such a way that, after a long internal struggle (not with moral principles but with his own weakness and indecision) he decides on a desperate expedient.

After much reflection he prepares to murder the girl by the upsetting of a boat—which will appear to be the result of an unfortunate accident.

He ponders all the details with the exaggerated carefulness of the inexperienced criminal—a carefulness which in the end inevitably entangles such a dilettante in a fatal network of incontrovertible evidence.

And he sets out in a boat with the girl.

In the boat the conflict between pity for the girl and repugnance to her, between weak vacillation and the craving to snatch at brilliant material blessings, reaches its climax.

Half consciously, half unconsciously, in a wild inward panic, he overturns the boat.

The girl is drowned.

Leaving her to her fate, Clyde makes his escape in the way he had planned beforehand, and is caught in the meshes of the net which he himself had woven.

The affair with the boat takes places as similar incidents take place; it is not sharply defined and complete; it is like a tangled skein. And Dreiser presents the incident quite impartially, leaving the further course of events to be shaped by the logical evolution not of the subject but . . . of the course of the law.

We had to emphasize Clyde's ACTUAL and TECHNICAL innocence in connexion with the actual perpetration of the crime.

Only by this means could we make sufficiently plain the "monstrous challenge" to a society whose mechanism brings a rather characterless youth into such a situation and then, invoking morality and justice, seats him in the electric chair.

The sanctity of the FORMAL principle in the codes of honour, morality, justice and religion is regarded in America as something primary and fundamental.

On this principle is based the endless game of advocacy in the courts and the matching of lawyers and parliamentarians one against the other. The



"The First Right of Children" (From the Diary of a Woman-doctor), a Deutsches-Lichtspiel-Syndikat Film.

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essence of the question ostensibly in dispute is an altogether subsidiary matter.

Therefore, the conviction of Clyde, even if essentially deserved in virtue of the part which he essentially played in the affair (which does not interest any one) would, if he were technically innocent, be regarded in America as something monstrous, as a judicial murder.

Such is the shallow, but transparent and unshakable psychology of the American, which accompanies him everywhere.

It was not from books that I had become familiar with this side of the American character . . .

Therefore it was essential to develop this scene with the boat into an indisputably clear proof of TECHNICAL innocence.

Without, however, in any way whitewashing Clyde or acquitting him of blame.

The following treatment was adopted :

Clyde wants to murder the girl but he cannot.

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At the moment when resolute action is necessary, he stays his hand. Simply from weakness of will.

However, before his inward "failure," he succeeds in exciting in Roberta, the girl, such a feeling of terror, that, when he bends over to her, already vanquished and ready to abandon his design, she jumps away from him in alarm. The boat rocks and threatens to overturn. When, as he is trying to support her, his camera accidentally grazes her face, she finally loses her head; in her terror she stumbles and falls and the boat capsizes.

For greater emphasis we make her rise to the surface again. We even make Clyde attempt to swim to her rescue. But the machinery of crime that has been set in motion continues its work to the end—even against Clyde's will: with a faint cry of horror Roberta starts away from him, and, not being able to swim is drowned.

Clyde, who is a splendid swimmer, makes his way to the shore, and, on coming to his senses, continues to act in accordance with the fatal plan which he has drawn up for the intended crime and from which he has only deviated for a moment.

That the situation gathers greater psychological and tragic depth in this form is beyond dispute.

The tragic element becomes heightened to a sort of Greek "blind Moira—destiny," which, once conjured into existence, will not relax its hold of the person who has dared to provoke it.

It is elevated to a tragic casuality, which, once having entered upon its rights, impels to its logical conclusion the inexorable sequence of events which has been set in motion.

This crushing of a human being by a blind cosmic principle, by the inexorable course of laws over which he has no control constitutes one of the basic premises of antique tragedy. It symbolizes the passive dependence of the man of that day on the forces of nature. In this it is analogous to what Engels, in connexion with another age, writes about Calvin:

" . . . His doctrine of predestination was a religious expression of the fact that in the commercial world success or failure depend not on a man's energy or skill but on circumstances beyond his control." (Engels: "Historical Materialism").

Reversion to the atavism of primitive cosmic conceptions, visible through a chance present-day situation, is always one of the means of raising a dramatic scene to the heights of tragedy.

But our treatment is not confined to this. It is pregnant with significant stressing of a whole series of stages in the further course of events. . .

In Dreiser's book the rich uncle, for the sake of preserving the honour of the family, supplies Clyde with the means of defending himself.

The Counsel for the Defence has not really any doubt that Clyde has committed the crime.

None the less, he concocts a theory of a "change of heart" experienced by Clyde under the influence of love and his pity for Roberta.

Not bad when it is simply invented off hand.

But how far worse when there ACTUALLY was a change of heart. When the change of heart was the result of quite other motives. When there was no actual crime; while the Counsel for the Defence is convinced that there was a crime, and, by a flagrant lie, so near to and at the same time so far from the truth, slanders the accused in the attempt to whitewash and save him.

And, from the dramatic standpoint, it becomes still more fatal if, immediately after, by the ideology of your treatment you violate the proportions and the epic impartiality of Dreiser's narrative in yet another passage.

The whole of the second volume is almost entirely taken up with the trial of Clyde for the murder of Roberta and with the hounding on of Clyde to his final doom, to the electric chair.

Only in a few lines, however, is it indicated that the true aim of Clyde's trial and conviction has nothing to do with him. The aim is simply and solely to win the necessary popularity among the farming population (the work-girl, Roberta, was a farmer's daughter) for the prosecuting counsel, Mason, so that he may secure nomination as an elected judge.

The Defence take up a case which they know to be hopeless ("at the best—10 years penal servitude") merely as part of the same political campaign.

Belonging to the opposite political camp (but not by any means to a different class) their primary aim is to do their utmost to damage the chances of the odious candidate for judicial office.

For both sides alike Clyde is simply a means to an end.

Clyde is a pawn in the hands of a blind destiny, but he also becomes a pawn in the hands of a by no means blind machinery of bourgeois justice, a machinery which is nothing else than an instrument for the political machinations of by no means blind political intriguers.

Thus the individual case of Clyde Griffiths is expanded and generalised into what is really a tragedy of America as a whole, into a characteristic story of an American "young man" of the beginning of the 20th century. . . .

From the dramatic version all the elaborate complications of the judicial procedure are omitted and in their place appear the pre-electoral intrigues, visible behind the outward solemnity of the hall of justice, which is nothing else than the private arena of a pre-electoral contest.

But this radical treatment of the murder succeeds in deepening the tragedy of strong ideological emphasis upon yet another passage and another figure.

The mother.

Clyde's mother is the head of a religious mission. An embodiment of blind fanaticism. Of such absolute belief in an absurd religious dogmatism that her figure takes on a certain monumental quality, a halo of martyrdom, and wins our involuntary respect.

And this despite the fact that she is really the first concrete embodiment of the guilt of American society in relation to Clyde.

Her teaching and principles, her concentration on God and heavenly things instead of on the training of her son for work, were the first basic causes of the tragedy.

In Dreiser's story she fights to the last for her son's innocence. She works as legal reporter of a provincial newspaper in order to be able to be present at his trial. She, like the mothers and sisters of the black children from Scottsboro, tours America, giving lectures, in order to collect money with which to secure re-examination of Clyde's case in the Court of Appeal.

The mother acquires the definite sacrificial sublimity of a heroine. In Dreiser's story this sublimity is capable of winning sympathy for her moral and religious doctrines.



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In our version, Clyde, in the death-cell, confesses to his mother that he did not kill Roberta, but that he wanted to do so.

The mother, who clings to the ultra-Christian belief that a sin in thought is equivalent to a sin in deed, is deeply shocked.

And, by reason of a sublimity quite the opposite to that of the mother in Gorky's story, this mother too becomes her son's betrayer.

When she goes to the Governor to petition for the revocation of her son's sentence, she is embarrassed by the point-blank question: "Do you yourself believe in your son's innocence?"

At this moment, which is to decide the fate of her son, the mother is silent.

The Christian sophism as to the equality of action in thought and action in deed which is an absurd parody of dialectical principles, leads to the final tragic dénouement.

The petition is rejected and discredits alike the dogma and the dogmatism of its bearer. And this moment cannot be washed away by the mother's tears at her last leavetaking with the son whom she has, with her own hands, delivered over into the jaws of the Christian Baal. And the more poignant the sadness of the last scenes the more forcible is their exposure of this Mumbo Jumbo ideology.



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Here the curious formalism of American dogmatism would seem to be supplemented by the contradictory element of Messianism, which actually proves to be the same lifeless dogmatism of a formal principle in the domain of religion. And this is only natural, in as much as both are fostered to an equal degree by the same social class system.

By our treatment we succeeded, in our opinion, in tearing off at any rate some of the masks—though by no means all—from this monumental figure.

We reconstructed the mother's role as best we could.

The pastor, McMillan, we eliminated from the scenario entirely.

And Dreiser was the first to appreciate the merits of our reconstruction of his work.

Not without cause are we witnessing at the present time Dreiser's gradual desertion of the ranks of the *petit bourgeoisie* and his approach nearer and nearer to ourselves.

In our version, the tragedy within the framework of the novel is consummated much later.

The cell. And the electric chair. And the brightly polished spittoon—from personal observation in the prison of Sing-Sing—at his feet. All

this is merely the conclusion of an individual embodiment of that tragedy which continues to be enacted in the United States every hour and every minute, not in fiction but in fact.

It might perhaps be imagined that the formula we selected—the formula of a sociological treatise—would prove dry and didactic, but in fact it enhances the poignancy of the situation and affords a deeper insight into the types and characters of the protagonists.

And further it exercises a profound influence on the purely technical methods. It was thanks to this formula, for instance, that the idea of the “internal monologue” was finally evolved in connexion with cinematography. This idea has been engaging my mind for the last six years. That is to say, I was preoccupied with it before the advent of the sound film made possible its realization in practice.

We need, as we have seen above, an extremely clear and definite exposition of what was happening in Clyde's mind before the actual moment of the accident with the boat, and we saw clearly that this could not be done by a mere presentation of external happenings.

Knitted brows, rolling eyes, spasmodic breathing, contorted frame, a stony face, convulsive movements of the hands—all this emotional apparatus was inadequate to express the subtleties of the internal conflict in all its phases.

We had to photograph what was going on inside Clyde's mind.

We had to demonstrate audibly and visibly, the feverish torrent of thoughts, interspersed with external action, with the boat, with the girl sitting opposite, with his own actions.

The form of the internal monologue was evolved.

These montage sheets were wonderful.

Even literature is almost powerless in this domain. It has to confine itself to primitive rhetoric, as in Dreiser's description of Clyde's inward broodings, or to the still more blatant mendacity of the pseudo-classic tirades of O'Neill's heroes who, having enlightened the public as to what they are saying, enlighten it in a second monologue, uttered aside, as to what they are thinking.

The drama is even more impotent in this matter than orthodox literary prose.

The film alone has at its command the means of presenting adequately the hurrying thoughts of an agitated man.

Or, if literature can do it too, it can only be literature that transgresses its orthodox bounds.

It is brilliantly achieved, as far as is feasible within the harsh framework of literary limitations, in the immortal “inward monologues” of Leopold Bloom, in James Joyce's wonderful “Ulysses.”

And not in vain, when I met Joyce in Paris, did we eagerly discuss my plans in regard to the inward film monologue, which has far wider possibilities than the literary monologue.

Despite the fact that he is almost completely blind, Joyce was very anxious to see those parts of "Armoured Train" and "October" which, in the cinematographic sphere of cultivation of means of expression, proceed along kindred lines.

The inward monologue, as a literary method of abolishing the distinction between subject and object, with a view to a crystallized presentation of the hero's experiences, is first observable in the literary experimenters round about the year 1887, for instance, in Edouard Dujardin's "*Les Lauriers sont coupés*."

As a theme, as a philosophy, a perception, an object—not a method—of description, we meet with it, of course, before this date. Transition from the objective to the subjective and back again is pre-eminently characteristic of the writings of the romantics.

E. T. A. Hoffman, Novalis and Gérard de Nerval (in regard to the last-named, see "La Double Vie de Gérard de Nerval" by René Bizet).

But in them it is a method of literary narration, not of plot-weaving; and its forms are the forms of literary composition.

As a specific method of exposition, as a specific method of construction, we first encounter it in Dujardin; but it does not attain absolute literary perfection until 31 years later—in Joyce and Larbaud.

But only in the film, of course, can it find full expression.

For only the sound film is capable of reconstructing all the phases and the specific essence of the process of thought.

What splendid drafts of montage sheets these were!

Like thought, they proceeded now by means of visual images—with sound—synchronized or non-synchronized. Then, as sound—formless—or with sound images: sounds symbolizing objects.

Then suddenly, by the coinage of words formulated intellectually—intellectually and dispassionately, and so uttered. With a black film—hurrying, formless visibility.

Now, by passionate incoherent speech. Only substantives. Or only verbs. Then by interjections. With zigzags of aimless figures, hurrying along with them synchronously.

Now, visual images hurried along in complete silence.

Now sounds were included in a polyphony. Now images. Then both together.

Now interpolating themselves into the external course of events, now interpolating elements of the external course of events into themselves.

Presenting, as it were, the play of thought within the *damatis personae*—the conflict of doubts, of bursts of passion, of the voice of reason, by

quick movement, or slow movement, emphasizing the difference in the rhythms of this one and that and, at the same time, contrasting the almost complete absence of outward action with the feverish inward debates—behind the stony mask of the face.

How fascinating to listen to one's own train of thought, particularly in a state of excitement.

To discover how one talks "inside oneself," as distinct from outwardly. To study the syntax of the internal as opposed to the external speech. To discover what quavering internal speech accompanies the simultaneous visual image. How they contrast with outward circumstances. How they react upon one another. . .

To listen and study with a view to grasping structural laws and combining them for the purpose of composing an internal monologue expressing with the utmost possible intensity the conflict of tragic experience.

How fascinating.

And what scope for creative invention and observation.



"*Schulze Versus Everyone*," a new Carl Froelich Verleiher-Kollektiv film. Ida Wüerst and Lilli Schönbaum.

"*Schulze contre tous*," nouveau film Verleiher-kollektiv de Carl Froelich. Ida Wüerst et Lilli Schönbaum.



"Schulze Versus Everyone."
 "Schulze contre tous."

And how obvious that the material of the sound film is in no sense—
 DIALOGUE.

THE TRUE MATERIAL FOR THE SOUND FILM IS, OF
 COURSE, THE MONOLOGUE.

And how unexpectedly, in its practical embodiment of the unforeseen particular concrete case of expressiveness, this completely harmonizes with the "last word" about montage form in general, which I had long foreseen theoretically: namely, that the montage form, regarded structurally, is the reconstruction of the laws governing the process of thought.

Here the special art of treatment, having evolved a completely new formal method, transcends its limits and embraces the theory of montage form as a whole. This, however, does not by any means imply that the process of thought as a MONTAGE FORM must always necessarily have as its SUBJECT too—the process of thought.

However, Mr. B. P. Schulberg and Mr. D. S. Washington did not allow the "red dogs" (our official nickname in fascist circles) to express

all this on the screen, to launch a "monstrous challenge" to American society and give practical expression to this 180 per cent. advance in sound film culture. . .

We parted and pursued our several ways, like ships on the ocean. . .

. . . And von Sternberg filmed the piece—directly, literally—the other way round, as it were, discarding everything on which we had based our conception and including in the picture everything that we had discarded.

The idea of an "internal monologue" never entered von Sternberg's head. . .

Von Sternberg confined his attention to what actually made a straight detective story.

Dreiser himself, like a grey-haired lion, fought for our so-called "distortion" of his work, and wrathfully did battle against the Paramount people, who had produced a formally and outwardly correct version of his subject.

Two years later the screen witnessed O'Neill's "Strange Interlude," which, by its dual and triple reproduction of speaking voices round the silent figure of the hero, still further aggravated the ponderous clumsiness of his dramaturgical cuneiform script. A flagrant caricature of the montage possibilities of the internal monologue.

The work of our collective regisseur is of a similar type. The definition and estimation of a work by means of the treatment. But, above all, with a realization of the constructively artistic and formerly fruitful role of what has here become a tedious and forced ideologicality and ideological persistence.

Realization not in a scheme but in the living organism of the production. This is the principal work which confronts our collective regisseur—the collective regisseur of the 3rd course of GIK.

And though we shall seek the actual theme for this work in every tract of the ocean of diverse and striking thematic material around us, I believe, none the less, that the first experiment along our path will be the evolution of a film on a theme that has long been awaiting treatment—the theme of the "20th Century Youth"—"the youth of the U.S.S.R."

Moscow, October, 1932.